

How long after the error can I still recover my data?

That isn't exactly the right question, to be honest. For recovering data doesn't depend on the time, but on how much data you've written to the drive since deleting it. We just talked about how the data is still available on the hard disk, but is just invisible to the operating system. So basically, whenever there's data to be stored on that drive, the OS might just allocate the now free space to it, thus overwriting the data that was already present there. If this happens, then you can be absolutely sure that there's no chance of recovering that data.

Hypothetically, if you delete a particular file, immediately shut down your computer and don't operate it for another ten years, you should still be able to recover that file once you start the computer again (provided it's still in working condition, and your mom/spouse/roommate let you continue to keep that thing in the house). If, on the other hand, you continue to use your computer normally, store some videos, browse the internet etc. there's a very high chance that the file recovery process may not go as well as you'd hoped, as the existing data might have been overwritten by the new data.

So you need to be extremely careful about the next step once you've realised that your data is gone if you want to recover that content. Sure, there's the slight chance that the OS might place new data in some section of the disk that isn't occupied by the old data – but there's great risk associated with that. Even if you download, let's say, 1 MB of new data, there's the likelihood of it being stored in an area, which belonged to a 100MB cluster – thus possibly corrupting the entire 100MB file. That's one of the reasons why even surfing the internet immediately after the error (possibly to look for recovery tools) is discouraged, because the browser automatically begins to download files on to your hard disk without your permission (even if you've disabled cookies). This might just overwrite some of your existing data. That's one of the reasons why if there's an option to choose between portable recovery software and installed software, try to go with the portable option.

Considering that the best way to recover data requires that you not even run the drive anymore, it's better to take into account other feasible options – such as getting an additional drive. Since this drive is not in peril of losing its data, load the recovery software onto it. Only then, will you attach it to your computer and its “bad” drive and run the software to recover as much data as possible from your PC's hard disk. Doing this